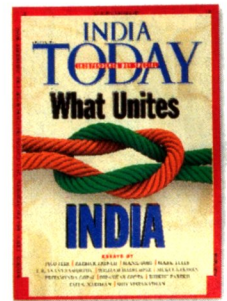


mail of the week

RAVI S SAHANI



"What Unites India",
August 20, 2007

"India is arguably the only nation which completely transcends all barriers of caste, colour, creed and religion. Our grit is the ultimate unifying factor."

K. CHIDANAND KUMAR, *Bangalore*

United and How

The cover of the magazine depicting Hindu-Muslim unity says it all ("What Unites India", August 20). It is primarily the thread of secularism that has kept the country united all these years.

S. BALAKRISHNAN, *Jamshedpur*

One cannot talk of national integration when we continue to ignore the contribution of different regions of the country, especially the south. All the talk about India being a single nation comes to a naught when we see people still thinking on regional lines.

K.R. RAVI, *USA*

The reason why India still stands united is the strength of its democracy, which has been nurtured in the past 60 years. For a democracy to function, differences of opinion must be respected. However, cases of Taslima Nasreen being

attacked smack of intolerance, which cannot be permitted in a democracy.

S. BALACHANDRAN, *Mumbai*

There are two peculiar traits that characterise Indians—one, our ability to function despite the motley group of corrupt politicians, bureaucrats and religious fanatics and two, our propensity to park and urinate at exactly the same place where we are prohibited from doing so.

SANDEEP PADHI, *Jeypore, Orissa*

Instead of asking "what unites India", we should ask "what divides India". Being united is a natural characteristic of the people of a nation. No other country asks such a question except India. It only portrays the fact that the forces behind the Partition are operational even today.

LAKSHMI NARAIN, *Meerut*

What makes the issue refreshingly different is

that in glorifying the country's achievements, the writers have not blithely swept its shortcomings under the carpet, but have instead tried to address them by suggesting practical solutions to pave the way for a better India.

NALINI VIJAYARAGHAVAN,
Thiruvananthapuram

The credit for the impeccable secular credentials of the country must go to the amiable tenets of Hinduism, the followers of which make up the majority of our population. Had that not been the case, we too would have ended up being an intolerant and theocratic state just like our two neighbours.

VIBHAKAR PATEL, *on e-mail*

Faith Matters

Religion has been the essence of Indian civilisation ("The Sacred and the Secular", August 20). It is time that our Government

formulated policies based on constructive and progressive elements of religion instead of blocking its expansion in the lives of the people.

ARVIND K. PANDEY, *Allahabad*

Politics of Unity

There may be 60 reasons why India is united—from education to economics, from media to music, but power and politics stay supreme ("United We Rule", August 20). The rise of regional parties will only help in keeping the flock together.

A. JACOB SAHAYAM,
Thiruvananthapuram

The magazine is wrong in saying that Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi did not sacrifice ideology for power. While the mother befriended all sorts of communal forces to ensure her survival and electoral success, the son, by getting an act passed to dilute the